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XXLargely seen

The visibility, accessibility and ideal fashion future for plus size people



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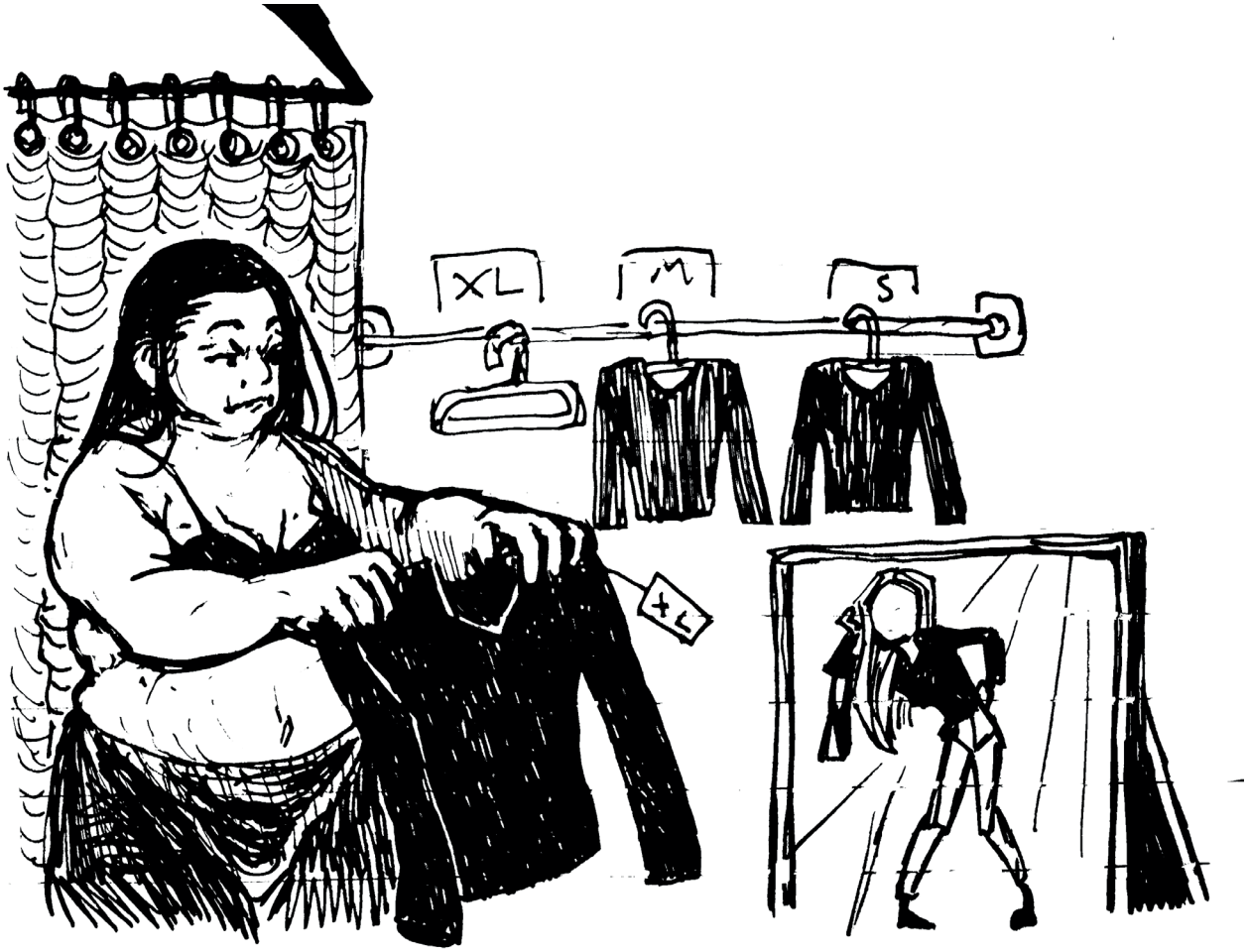


Fig. 1 “XL should fit, right?”, Lundgren, 2024

Keywords:

Body image, Inclusiveness, Speculative design, Beauty standards, Fashion

Abstract:

The report deals with the topic of plus size fashion and its lack of visibility within the general fashion market, and how greater visibility could affect the legitimacy of plus size fashion as a market category. In this project, a speculative design methodology was used, which divided the process into two stages, “what is?” and “what if?”. The first stage was devoted to data collection, through observations in stores and questionnaires directed to plus size people. In the second stage, a co-design session was conducted together with a group of plus size people who participated in designing a store space that would meet their needs and wants as customers, using the ideal fashion future (IFF) mapping that I designed beforehand. Taking the results from the mapping, I visualized a store based on the ideas brought up by my co-designers, in order to present our work to the general public together with the question “What could be a new way to do store design (and the implications that come with those design changes) that does not exclude people with different body types?”

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Table of contents:

1. Introduction 3
2. Background 3
    2.1. Visibility in the fashion market 4
3. How does sustainability enter the picture? 5
    3.1. The four spheres 5
    3.2. Metadesign 7
4. What is the change? 8
    4.1. Design theory - Speculative design 8
    4.2. Collaborators 8
    4.3. Ethics 9
    4.4. Design role 9
5. First stage: ”what is?” 10
    5.1. Aim 10
    5.2. Methods 10
        5.2.1. Field study 10
        5.2.2. Questionnaire 12
        5.2.3. Meeting with collaborator - second questionnaire 12
6. Second stage: ”What if?” 13
    6.1. Aim 13
    6.2. Methods 13
        6.2.1. New mapping method 14
        6.2.2. Co-design 15
    6.3. Gathering results 16
    6.4. Visualization 19
7. Reflection 21
8. Summary 23
9. References 24

1. Introduction

In my design project, XXLargely seen, I have focused on the topic of plus size fashion in the fashion industry and market. Using speculative design as methodology, I split my project into two stages: the “what is?” (current state) and “what if?” (future possibilities). In the first stage I focused on collecting data, using field trip studies, questionnaires with my target group (plus size people), and previous studies done by other researchers on the topic. In the second stage, I focused on ideating and collaborating with plus size people, with the goal to co-design with them and then visualize what an ideal future would look like for the plus size fashion market.

2.Background

To begin this report, I would like to guide you through a story.
Imagine yourself walking into a clothing store, looking for a new pair of jeans and a shirt. As you enter the store you are met with sale signs, mannequins, advertisements featuring models wearing the latest collection, and personnel moving around the racks, putting each piece of clothing where it belongs.

You see that in terms of body shape, nothing here looks like you.

You move towards one of the racks and pick out a shirt that caught your eye. It is in size L. That should work, right? But you also know not to get your hopes up, so just in case you take a size XL with you for good measure. When looking for pants, you already know that going for the largest pair is the best course of action. After sorting through multiple pairs of jeans, you reach for a pair that is further in on the racks, size XL. These are the clothes you are now bringing to the fitting room.

You try to put on the shirts first. You find the shirt in size L to be very close to fit you, but unfortunately the arm holes are small and make it difficult for you to raise your arms. You also notice that doing so makes the shirt rise up and expose your stomach. You switch to the larger shirt. It feels more comfortable around the arms, although the shirt looks a little bit baggy on the rest of your body. You know you can tuck the shirt into your pants to mitigate the effect. Years of finding clothes that do not quite fit have taught you to be creative with styling your clothes.

Now it is time to try on the pants, and you find that the pants stop at your hips. You are confused, you thought that the largest size should have worked. You go to ask the cashier if they have the pants in a larger size, and you see them head towards the storage room. A larger size exists, it is just stored in the back, out of view, only brought to light when someone asks for it. When you try these pants, you find that you can zip them, but they sit tight around the waist, which does not feel comfortable.

You leave the store with a new shirt.

This story might sound familiar to you, or it might not. It truly depends on whether you fit the standards of the current fashion market. I do not. And this story is a glimpse into the experiences I have to navigate through when getting new clothes, in a body too large and wide to fit into most clothes.

During this project, I wanted to look more deeply into scenarios like the one I told. Why is it such a struggle to find clothes that fit when you are plus size? When looking for clothes that are bigger, you will find less of them on display than the smaller sizes. It is more common to find them in their storage or on their online store.

When it comes to clothing made for people larger than average, there is little effort being made to openly display clothing for us in the same way it is displayed for thinner people. But it goes deeper than that. A store can make you feel seen even before you look at the clothes. Models, mannequins and layout of the space affect this as well, where we currently see that thinness takes center stage. The mannequins are long and thin, and the plus size brands are designated to areas of the store that are not visible for a person looking in from outside. Speaking bluntly, plus size clothing is treated as a separate component from the general fashion market, in a way that leads to a lack of visibility for plus size people.

2.1. Visibility in the fashion market

What do I mean when I talk about visibility in this context? Visibility here means not only to see yourself in the clothes, the advertisements and the models, but to see yourself as an ideal for people to want to replicate. In the article *Dynamics between market categories: A study of the (in) visibility of the plus-size fashion market (2020)*, authors Delphine Dion and Béatrice Tachet write about the relationship between the general fashion market and the plus size fashion market. In their text they refer to two types of visibility: symbolic visibility and physical visibility. Symbolic visibility is described as the ideal body and look that society wants to uphold. That ideal becomes the prototype for the fashion industry to use in clothes manufacturing, advertising and modeling, which is what becomes the physical visibility of the ideal. Looking at the current fashion market, we see that long and thin is the ideal body (Dion and Tachet 2020, 9). It has become the standardization within clothes production, where small and large clothing is only changed in scale, not in shape.

During my project, I talked with a lot of plus size people, and I noticed that a lot of them were feeling a sense of worry and defeat. Many of them had stores that they put a lot of trust in to provide clothing for them, but recent news, like Monki discontinuing its plus size collection as well as removing the advertisements for it (Bridfelt 2024), had left them wary of other stores following this example. To many of them, the future looked bleak.

The lack of visibility in the current fashion market is not just affecting a plus size person's ability to get clothing, but also their ability to dream of a future that could provide something better for them.



Fig. 2 Symbolic visibility that leads to the standard, Lundgren, 2024

3. How does sustainability enter the picture?

3.1. The four spheres

My main focus of sustainability is on the socio-economic and cultural aspects of plus size fashion, as the legitimacy as a market, which economy and culture both have a hand in, is what is affecting the social structures currently in place. What legitimacy as a market means economically, is that there is financial gain to be had by tapping into it. As can be seen in the article by Dion and Tachet (2020), as well as the field studies I made, is that people in the industry deem this market to be a financial risk. "Informants from the fashion industry told us about the economic risk inherent in broadening the spectrum of sizes. They referred to low profitability, limited additional revenue, poor stock rotation and constraints in terms of price, production and storage space, and so on" (Dion and Tachet 2020, 14). When an additional size to a collection is included, production costs go up and in order to profit from it you need to make the price higher. This becomes an issue when you are in competition with other store brands, especially big ones like H&M, that sell their mass-produced collections for far more affordable prices. This is the economic factor that causes hesitancy amongst store owners to include plus size fashion. But if there is a group, plus size people in this case, who really need clothing, would it not be beneficial for a store to cater to them and have them become loyal customers?

This is where the cultural aspect of sustainability shows up, and how it is connected to the physical visibility of plus size people in the market. It is no secret that despite the efforts made by body positivity movements and activists alike, we still have a beauty standard lying dominant in our culture, that is long and thin (Yixing and Zhang 2023). Just like how the beauty standard remains, so does the stigma around fatness. And while stores are capable of showcasing larger models as part of their branding, which is encouraged in our current age of striving for progress, there is still a hesitancy towards promoting plus size fashion due to the stigma. A hesitancy due to not wanting to promote unhealthy lifestyles that feeds into the attempts to make plus sizes invisible. This in turn makes it so that there is a lack of communication between stores and their potential target group, leading to plus size people not finding themselves welcome into the space, which is what furthers the plus size fashion market's illegitimacy.

A lot of plus size people have told me they buy their clothes online, as the feeling of isolation is not as strongly felt when you are not personally in a store, as well as the fact that online stores are upfront with the size ranges in a way that is easier to navigate. But a reliance on online shopping is not a solution, as it could lead to social isolation, as well as transportation of clothes has a negative effect on the environment. There is always a risk of clothing bought online not fitting well. A reason for this is that our current size chart is not reliable when figuring out if something fits, two shirts can both be in size L and fit completely differently. Only a few stores provide detailed measurements for the clothes they sell online, but from the plus size people I have talked to, waist, bust and hip measurements are not enough to figure out whether the clothes fit or not.

In fig 3 I have compiled the research I have gathered, using the four spheres of sustainability map. In this map you can see how the topic of plus size fashion touched on economical, ecological, social and cultural sustainability, and how they intersected. This showcases the complexities that could be found within the topic, and what I wanted to address through my project.

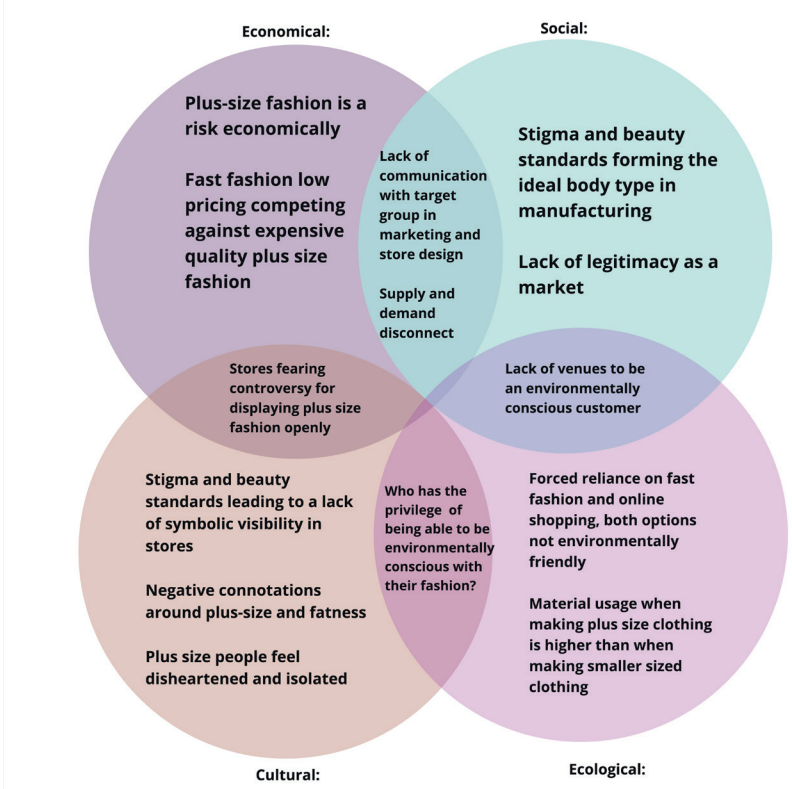


Fig. 3 Project XXLargely seen mapped in the four spheres of sustainability, Lundgren, 2024, Four sustainability spheres (a metadesin framework used in the Department of Design), adapted from e.g. Jones, H. and Lundebye, L. (2006) Metadesign: A Dynamic Framework for Seeding Socially Responsive Design. In: 8th International Conference on Design and Emotion. Central Saint Martins, United Kingdom 5/25/2006.

3.2. Metadesign

Mapping the project in the four spheres of sustainability is one way to think through complexities. Another is to visualize the product, system and paradigm layers through a metadesign map. This map showed what components were a part of the topic that I wanted to address, from the cultural mindset (paradigm) that leads to the current standard we see in clothes production (system) that leads to the clothes we find in our local stores (product). On the right side of the map I had placed my own project within these three layers. By using the metadesign map I positioned my project on the paradigm level, as it was the current symbolic visibility and its trickle down effect on the system and product levels I wanted to criticize.

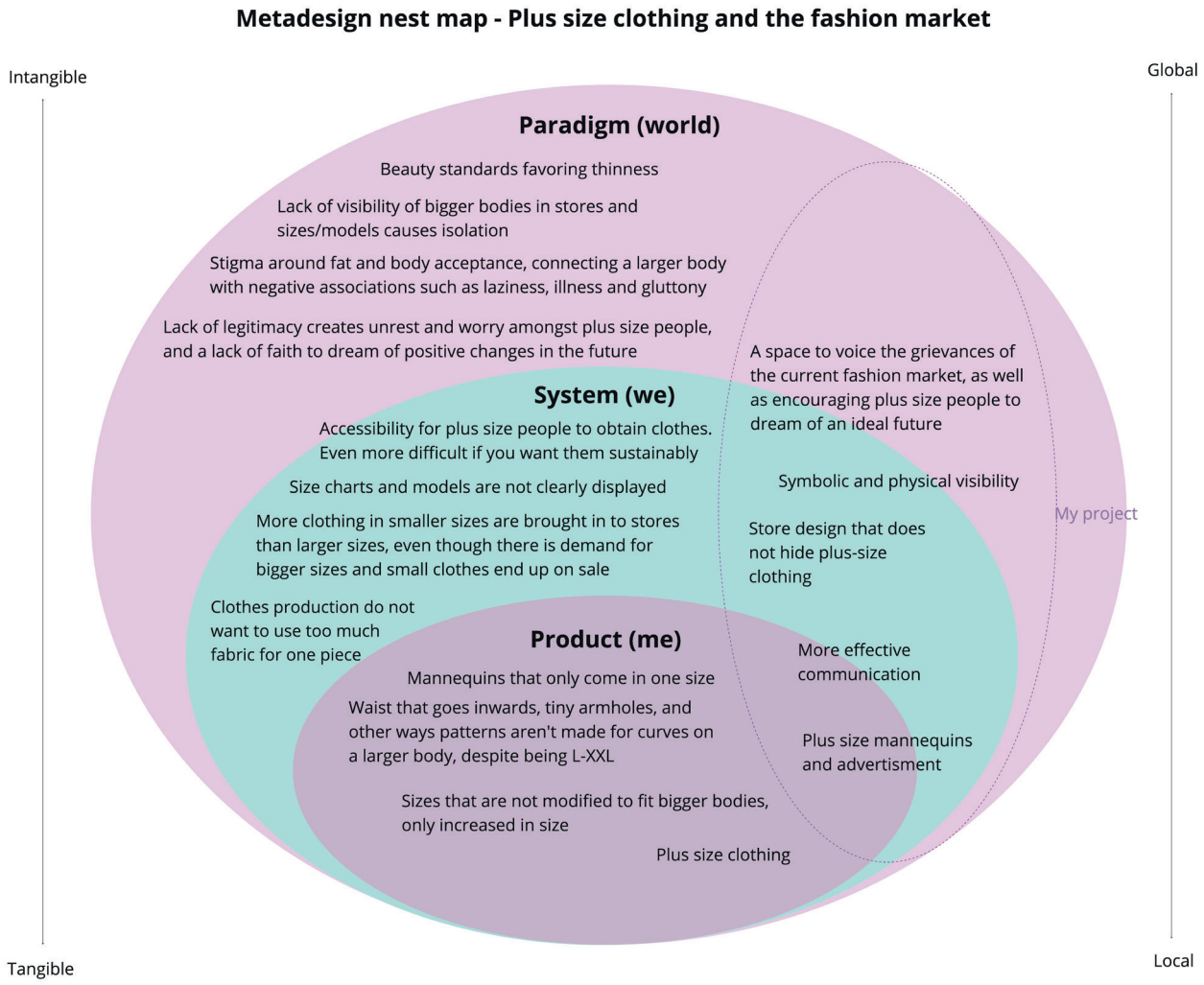


Fig. 4 Metadesign nest map - Plus size clothing and the fashion market, Lundgren, 2024, Metadesign nests (a metadesign framework used in the Department of Design), see e.g. Tham, M., Ståhl, Å., Hyltén-Cavallius, S. (2019) Oikology - Home Ecologics: a book about building and home making for permaculture and for making our home together on Earth. Växjö: Linnaeus University Press.

4. What is the change?

With this project I wanted to reach out to plus size people and have a co-designing session of an ideal future that takes the needs and wants of the group fully into account. By imagining a future that makes plus size people feel visible both symbolically as well as physically, in a way that is tangible for people to understand, I could effectively communicate how the current fashion industry could improve. As a designer I wanted to create a space for this discussion, where I do not just bring attention to where we, as a society, are lacking in terms of plus size visibility and accommodation, but to also inspire us to envision an ideal future we want to reach.

4.1. Design theory - Speculative design

For this project I have used the speculative design method to guide me. Anthony Dunne and Fiona Raby, authors of the book *Speculative Everything: Design, fiction, and social dreaming*, refer to speculative design as something that:

> Thrives on imagination and aims to open up new perspectives on what are sometimes called wicked problems, to create spaces for discussion and debate about alternative ways of being, and to inspire and encourage people's imaginations to flow freely. Design speculations can act as a catalyst for collectively redefining our relationship to reality (2013, 2).

The "wicked problems" in my case being the lack of visibility and legitimacy of plus size clothing as part of the general fashion market. I wanted to use this method for the project as I am interested in what future we want as plus size people. It is this mindset that has shaped my practices for the project, by focusing on where the wicked problems lie and how I can respond to them through imagining alternatives.

4.2. Collaborators

My collaboration can be sorted into two groups: the people in the fashion industry, and plus size people as the target group.

On a visit to Norrköping I met up with a small store owner who wanted to cooperate with me with the data collection. In her store I was allowed to leave small posters with links leading to a questionnaire. The store owner, who shall remain anonymous, has built up a good reputation with her customers, due to the wider size range of clothes she sells, as well as helping customers who are unsure how to style themselves in accordance with their body type. These qualities are what made me reach out to her, as I knew she shared the same goal of providing a space for plus size people in the fashion market, and that she has built enough trust in this space for me to get access to her customer base.

I knew from the beginning that I wanted to have plus size people take part in the design process with me. At first, I had reached out through questionnaires online and on pinboards on the streets of Växjö, as well as on the Linnaeus University campus. Getting people interested in my project was not easy. My initial plan had been to gather participants to be part of a workshop, but questions from my teaching team came up in regard to inviting a huge group to discuss a rather sensitive topic. After considering the ethical implications behind this, I decided to make the co-design process in one-on-one sessions.

4.3. Ethics

Since my project involved the topic of stigmatization of plus size fashion, I needed to be in discussion with people who are affected by this. This meant that I had to address the topic of weight and size in a sensitive and compassionate manner with my plus size collaborators. Body image issues caused by lack of access, invisibility in stores and our current beauty standards leave people more prone to body anxiety and feelings of isolation. As a larger person myself, I was in a position where I had more leeway to discuss this in a way that does not feel condescending to my target group. Although I do also acknowledge that I am on the lower spectrum of plus size, where clothes in size XL do fit me. This is a privilege in this case, even if I have faced the stigma and difficulties with fashion and body image before. These issues are not something that only affects one group of course. Our focus on beauty standards and the need to chase that ideal is what causes body image issues to begin with for the majority of people and plus size people especially. As authors Yixing Tang and Jiacheng Zhang put it: “In a socio-aesthetic culture that associates personal worth with physical appearance, slimness symbolizes self-assurance, self-discipline, and success. At the same time, overweight individuals are often stigmatized as having low self-esteem, laziness, and a lack of achievement” (2023, 1). When conducting my co-design work with my collaborators, I made sure to make a safe space for them to feel encouraged to participate. The co-designers were informed of what their involvement would be used for, and that they would be kept anonymous. This was to ensure that they felt like they knew what they had chosen to participate in, as well as give them the safety of anonymity to be more bold in their ideas.

4.4. Design role

Within this project I took on different roles as a designer depending on at what stage in the process I was. In the first stage “what is?” I worked as a design researcher, collecting data from the fashion industry and plus size people, that would help me gain a greater understanding of the topic. In the second stage “what if?” I put myself in the role of a counselor and facilitator, leading my collaborators through a co-design session I conducted, guiding them through the process of creating a new ideal store space.

Communication was a big factor for my project, as the issue of invisibility can only be brought into public consciousness by facilitating a space for it. My final outcome was to communicate the needs and wants of the plus size people I worked with, who felt that the current market had not taken them into consideration. For me, as a designer and a change agent, I felt the need to not just criticize the current state of the fashion market, but to inspire people to look for new innovative ideas on how to make the space more size inclusive.

5. First stage: “What is?”

In this stage I have been gathering data on plus size fashion in the general fashion market through different methods.

5.1. Aim

The aim was to get more informed on the topic, not just from my own experiences, but from other plus size people. This would help me understand what the current dilemmas are amongst plus size fashion and its target group on a bigger scale, which would help inform me how to proceed with the second stage.

5.2. Methods

I used two methods for data collection: a field study where I visited different clothing stores in Växjö, and two questionnaires directed to my target group.

5.2.1. Field study

For this field study I wanted to find out what the visibility of plus size fashion looked like in stores today, by going to multiple clothing stores and secondhand shops. I looked for placement of the clothes, how the clothes were shaped depending on the size, and what models (advertisements and mannequins) would be seen wearing them. The commonalities I found were:

- Mannequins are all thin with rarely any difference in body type.
- Models in advertising majorly favored thinner bodies.
- The size range is clearer on the store’s website rather than in the physical store.
- The amount of clothing in size XS-M is bigger than clothes in size L and up.

When asking one employee from the clothing store *NewYorker* about their assortment of clothing, they told me that they take in more clothes in smaller sizes than larger clothes, despite the fact that many customers ask for the larger sizes. They did not know why this was the case, which meant that I could not find an answer directly from the source. From the data I have
gathered in this part of the project, I do see how a lack of prototype for plus size people leads to a lack of visibility in a store space, as the majority of bodies displayed in these spaces are long and thin. Even by looking at clothes, I could see that the waist goes inward and the armholes are small, something that stays the same on the larger sizes of these clothes despite the fact that it would not fit well on a larger body.





Fig. 5 Two mannequins in Stadium, Grand Samarkand, Lundgren, 2024

Fig. 6 Sales rack at Åhléns, Lundgren, 2024

The way this field trip contributed to my project was by providing me data to prove the lack of physical visibility in our current fashion market, as well as providing me a list of components that make up a clothing store. This list ended up becoming important for the second stage of the project, where the goal was to design a new store space.

5.2.2. Questionnaire

For my project, I wanted to reach out to more plus size people, to make sure my decisions were not solely based on my experiences. I decided to make a questionnaire to gather the data, and spread posters with QR links to it over the Linnaeus University campus and in the city center of Växjö. With this questionnaire I asked for people's opinions on:
- The size charts being used,
- How efficiently they can find clothes in their size inside a store,
- What piece of clothing they found to be the most difficult to find in the right size,
- If they felt seen when they walked into a store.

Despite the posters I put up, I found the amount of participants in this questionnaire to be lacking. Over the course of a week I only managed to get three answers, where a few of the answers I got were telling me they were confused by my questions. Looking back, I can see why that was the case. I believe that by delving deep into the topic of visibility and fashion I might not have adjusted the way I spoke about them so that they would be easily understood. In order to have a more successful questionnaire, I needed to simplify my questions, as well as make sure I could garner more answers. This is the moment in my project where my first collaborator entered the picture.

5.2.3. Meeting with collaborator - second Questionnaire

On a visit to Norrköping, I met up with a small store owner in the city. The store owner, who shall remain anonymous, was willing to help me with the project.

The reason why I picked her to be my collaborator was because I have had personal experience of visiting her store beforehand and finding a huge assortment of clothes that fit me. I remember it being quite an emotional experience, as I had previously not found clothes shopping to be a fun activity in my teen years, for many reasons already mentioned in this report. My collaborator seemed to be on the same page as me. As a plus size woman herself, she found the size ranges in current stores to be severely lacking, so when she handpicks her clothes she makes sure to have a size range as wide as possible. Her large clothing assortment and sheer attentiveness when helping her customers find clothes that fit, has led to her gaining a lot of trust amongst her customer base.

I was made aware of how much trust matters in the plus size fashion market, when I heard that she was retiring and selling the store to someone else, which had led to her customers reacting with worry. "If you are not here anymore, I don't know if I can find clothes for me!" was one of the responses she had received from a customer. The trust aspect to this topic was something that I had not considered before, but hearing this story from my collaborator made me realize what a huge part it plays in the longevity of a store. By showing your customer base that you are knowledgeable and attentive to their needs, you make the bond stronger between the buyer and seller. It led me to think of the plus size clothing that is scarce in stores in our current day, and that perhaps a stronger presence of plus size clothing and employees who are knowledgeable in clothes on different body types, could lead the plus size fashion market strengthening its legitimacy and not be considered a financial risk.

With the help of my collaborator, I made a new questionnaire that would be addressed to her customer base. Within a week I had eight participants who responded. Here is what I garnered from their responses:

- A majority of them got their clothing from shopping in stores or online.
- They found looking for clothes in physical stores to be difficult, which affected their self esteem.
- It was not easy to find affordable clothing in plus size.
- Their needs were to find clothes in good quality, that fit them and felt comfortable, something they felt were limited in current stores, which has led to feel like their needs were not seen.
- They wanted to be able to see more of themselves in current store spaces and to be able to shop physically and not be forced to buy clothes online. They felt that the current fashion market did not care for them as a customer base for this to happen.

The result from this questionnaire showed me that this topic really needed to be brought into light. Seeing in some of these responses, how a lack of visibility had led to the participants losing confidence in their own body, made me realize the importance of my project as a way to bring plus size awareness to the public. It also showed me that I was not alone in my observations. Many participants had pointed out that their choices in clothes stores were limited and that they were relegated to online stores. The results from this questionnaire strengthened my confidence that I would be able to get good participation from plus size people when entering the second stage of my project.

6. Second stage: “What if?”

In this stage of the project I prepared to host a co-design session with plus size people, which would then help inform me what the final outcome of my project would be.

6.1. Aim

The aim was to make a space for co-design with plus size people, where the goal was to let them design a clothing store that would address their wants and needs. In other words, what would be their ideal fashion future. My role as designer was to act as a consultant during the co-design session, by guiding them through the process and helping them spark new ideas through discussion. After gathering the results, I merged them together to make one store space, where I emphasized all new design ideas from my collaborators. I would later make visualizations of this new space, to be presented to the public as my speculative design.

6.2. Methods

My methods during this stage came in two parts, co-design and visualization. The first method needed some preparation though, both in what material to use as well as time, space and size of the group I would invite to the co-design session. Originally I wanted to create a workshop for a small group of plus size people, but I had no luck finding enough people to participate at one date, so I changed my approach to instead have the co-design be in one-on-one sessions. For the sessions I had created a new mapping method.

6.2.1. New mapping method

The Ideal Fashion Future (IFF) mapping method was made to help the co-designers visualize the store space they wanted to create. Taking inspiration from my field trip studies where I listed all components that make a clothing store, I included it in this map. What is new here is the leading questions I included:

- What do I as a plus size person want to see when stepping into this space?
- How do I want to be acknowledged in the space as a plus size person?
- Drawing on previous experiences of getting clothes as a plus size person, what do you wish to be different?

By implementing these questions into the mapping, I had given the list of components a new framing, where the focus became what role they serve to make the store space plus size inclusive. I had also included a question that asked the co-designer to think of the larger implications their ideas could have, on a production level which would be reflected in the store.

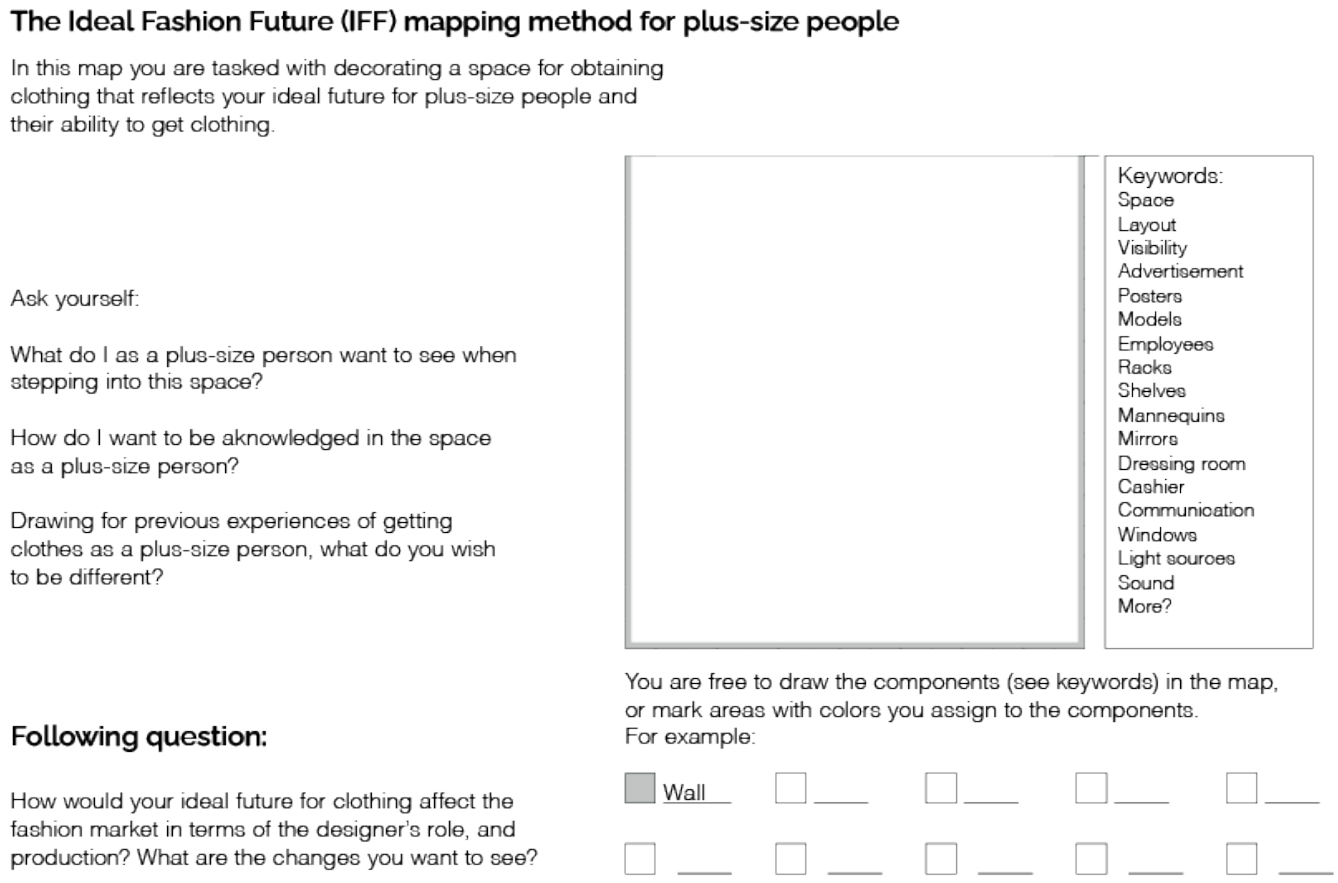


Fig. 7 The Ideal Fashion Future (IFF) mapping method for plus-size people, Lundgren, 2024

6.2.2. Co-design

For my co-design session I had three people who participated. One who participated in person and two, who due to time constraints, participated online. Due to these circumstances, the sessions with the online co-designers were much shorter, which meant that a lot of the design ideas were handed to me from them via email. From the session I had in person with the first participant, where I was able to notice and discuss any ideas they had, I came to the conclusion that in-person sessions were more beneficial for my project. That is not to say that the other participants have not contributed to the final design, it just means that I have more context to the design decisions made by the participant who I could talk directly with.

Each co-designer was given the IFF mapping on a paper where they were tasked with decorating the space to be a plus size inclusive store. As a starting point I would ask one of the leading questions on the mapping to prompt conversation, which would serve as inspiration for the participant when they designed the space. By doing this, the session naturally split into intervals of conversation and mapping, each part taking around 20-30 minutes.

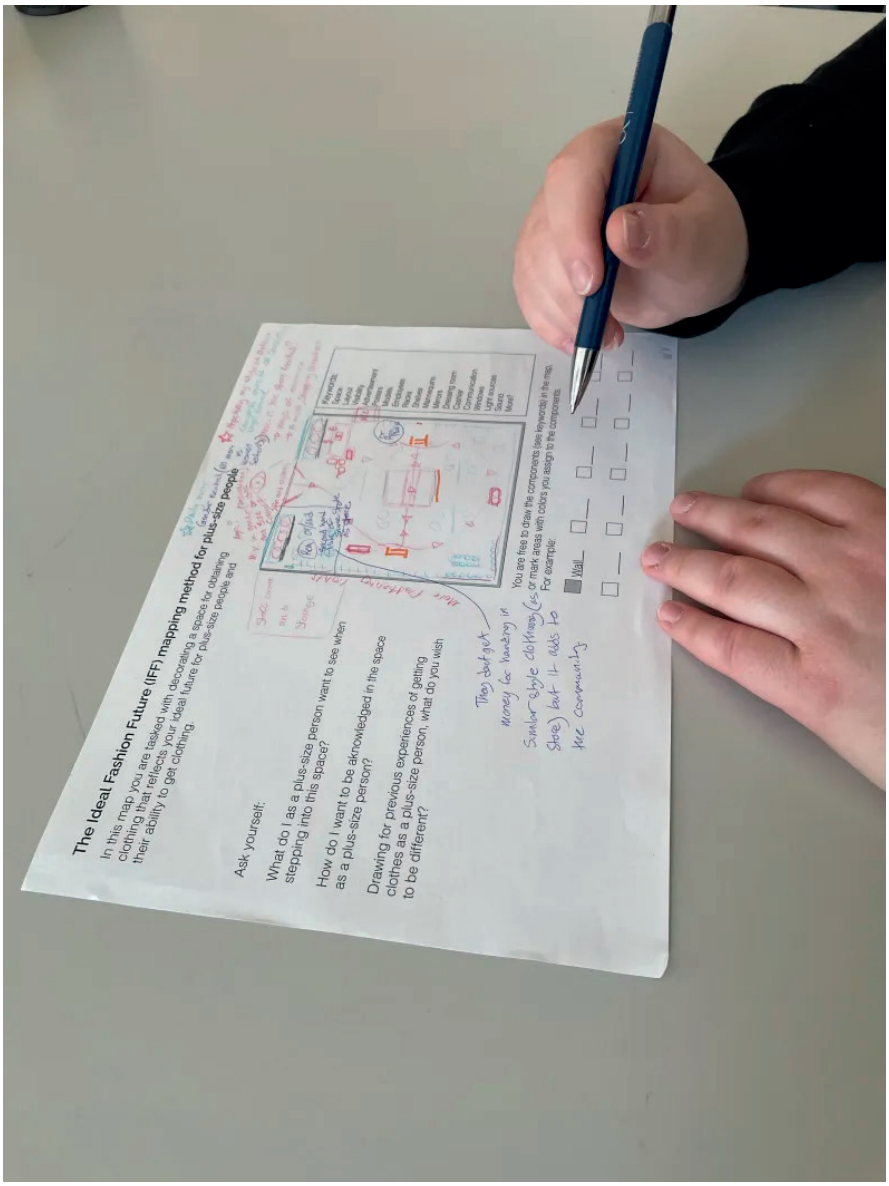


Fig. 8 Participation in IFF mapping, Lundgren, 2024

6.3 Gathering results

The results from the co-designers have been labeled as such: Participant 1, Participant 2 (online), and Participant 3 (online). Here is an overview of their design decisions:

Participant 1:

- Enough room in the space to walk between clothing racks with no problem
- Multiple models and mannequins in different sizes and body types
- Better communication with customers on how to find fitting clothes, both from personnel and through signs and booklets
- A new standardization where clothes are made to fit different body types as well as sizes, with charts and guides provided for customers
- A secondhand area in the store for giving people a more ecologically and economically sound option, which gives them also an option to provide clothes for the store to keep its longevity.
- Accommodations like a toilet, as well as seats inside the store and changing rooms.

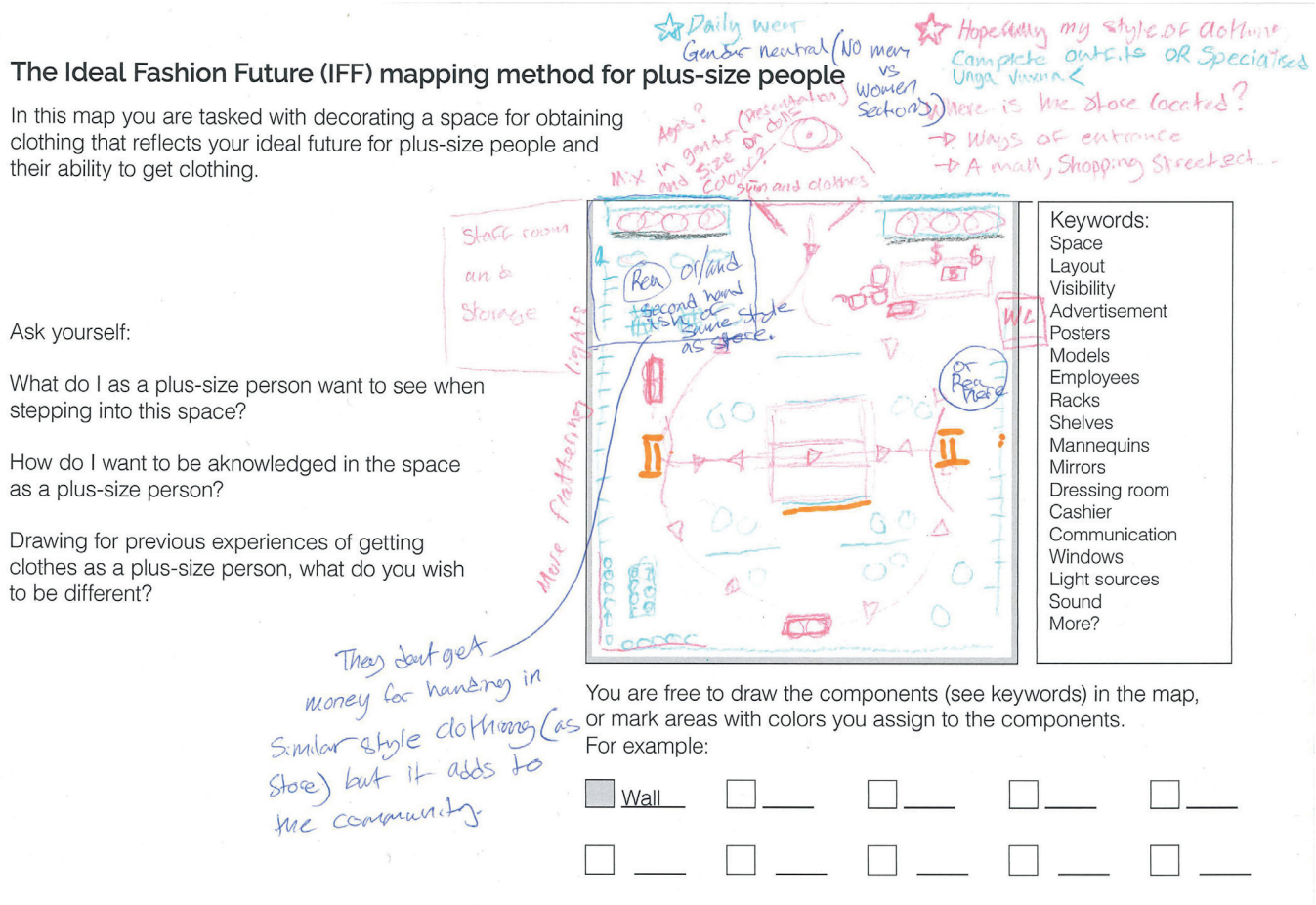


Fig. 9 IFF mapping by participant 1, Lundgren, 2024

Participant 2 (online):
- Enough room to walk in the store space, as well as in changing rooms
- Better communication from store personnel, as well as more clear signs that showcases the size ranges
- Mannequins and models in different sizes throughout the store
- A feeling of exclusivity, to feel welcomed into the space no matter the size.

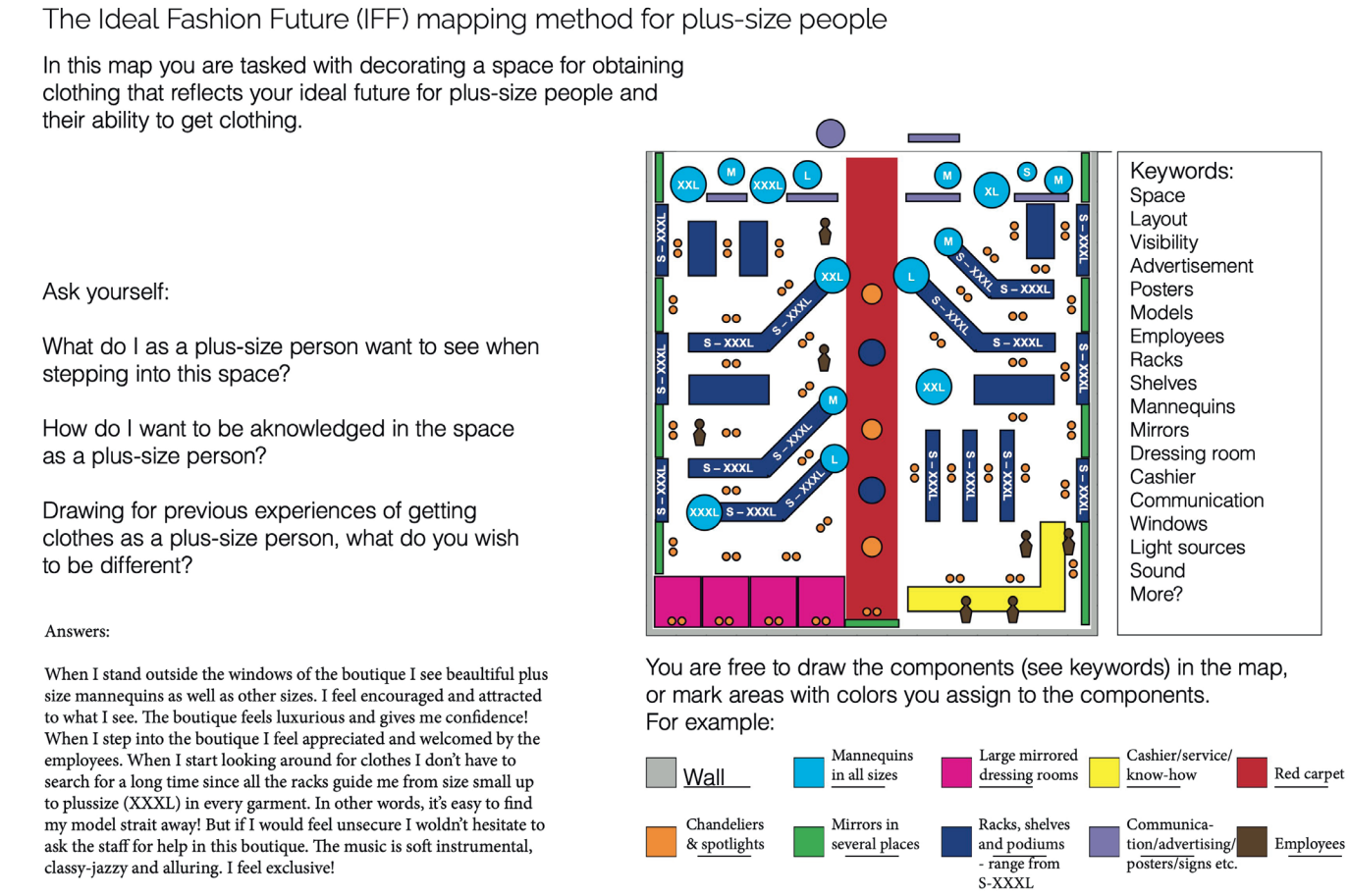


Fig. 10 IFF mapping by participant 2, Lundgren, 2024

Participant 3 (online):
- Mannequins and models in different sizes
- Attentive and knowledgeable personnel/AI
- Room in the space for displays of clothing, changing rooms and for walking
- Quality clothing that lasts long, which leads to less overconsumption
- A different checkout system where customers take a queue number to pay rather than standing in a line.

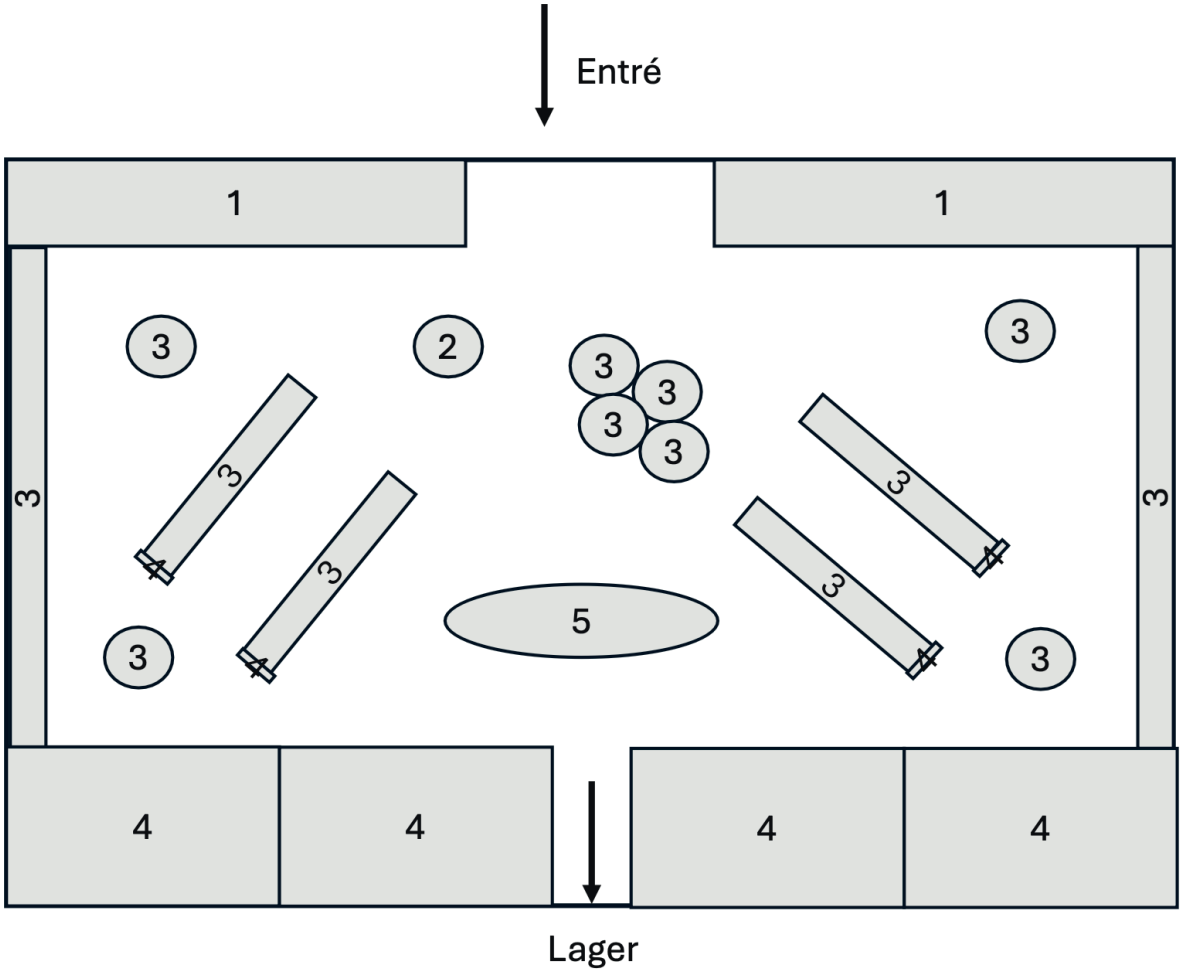


Fig. 11 IFF mapping by participant 3, Lundgren, 2024

From these results I could see similarities between the co-designers. All of them wanted more space to be able to move comfortably in the store. They all wanted the communication to be better in the store, whether it was through knowledgeable personnel, AI, guides and booklets, or signs. They all wanted models and mannequins to be more varied in size. What is interesting here is that participant 1 expanded on that by implementing different body types into the store, as an additional way to categorize clothes. This idea sparked my interest, due to the fact that this new categorization implies a change in standardization in the clothes production. Only by producing clothes using models with different body types, can this store exist. Participant 1 and 3 had both addressed the economical and ecological aspect of the store, by implementing a secondhand area and enforcing high quality clothing that lasts longer and does not encourage overconsumption. These overlapping ideas from the results made it easier for me to visualize the final outcome of this store, and thanks to participant 1 I had an idea for a name for it.

6.4 Visualization

The final outcome of this project was the accumulation and visualization of the store design my collaborators and I had made together. The first illustration serves as an overview of the store. I made it spacious in accordance with my co-designers, as well as making sure there were signs for each clothing display that clearly communicated the size range. There are multiple mannequins with different body types displayed here to showcase how the clothes look on different bodies. Some of these mannequins are wearing the same clothing in different sizes to show how the clothes here are tailored to fit anyone. In fact, body type diversity is a big aspect to this store's identity, as it is a new category to sort clothes. It can be seen in the second illustration, where a hand is holding up a shirt in front of the secondhand area, and the price tag has one letter from the store name colored purple. This was an idea I came up with after discussing with participant 1, where I based different body types on letters, which would then serve as the store name and a sorting category. This is how the name XAVIO came to be. In this speculative future we have five body types in clothes production, where they all have a distinct shape, as shown in the XAVIO chart illustration below.



Fig. 12 XAVIO store - overview, Lundgren, 2024



Fig. 13 XAVIO store - tags and secondhand, Lundgren, 2024

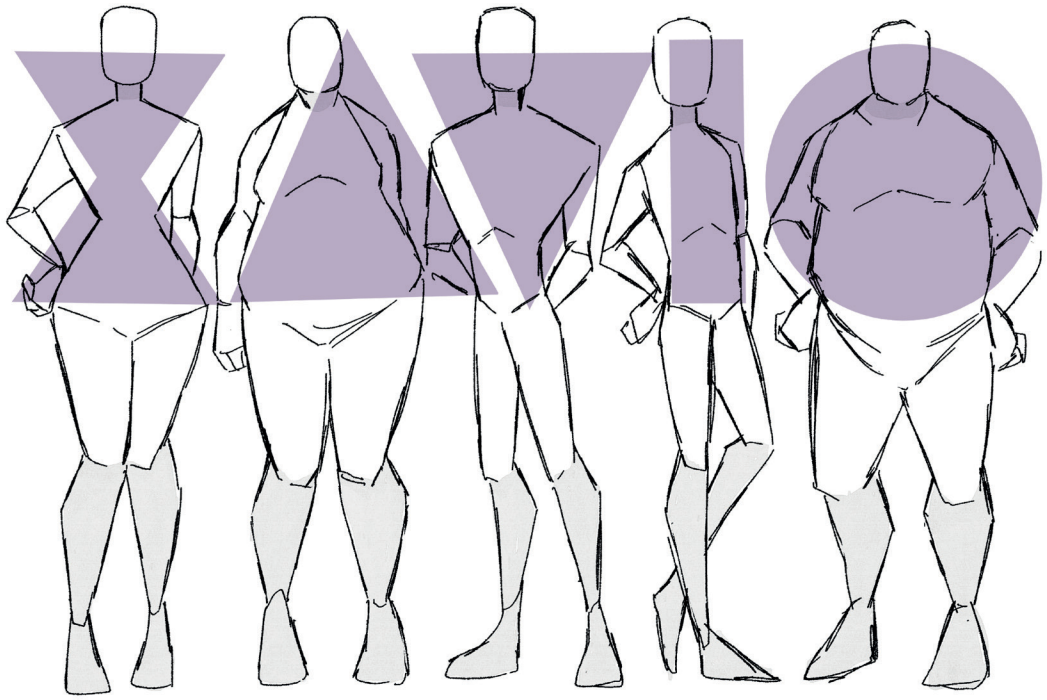


Fig. 14 The XAVIO chart, Lundgren, 2024

The purpose of these visualizations is to showcase where we are currently lacking in the fashion market in terms of body diversity, what a future where visibility of plus size fashion is implemented to stores can look like, as well as how the plus size fashion market can be legitimized by involving its customer base in design decisions. The way I wanted people to experience my project was by first seeing these visualizations with a title that said “What if stores were designed not to exclude?”. This way the person is already inclined to think about the underwhelming amount of body diversity in our current fashion market. For those who want to dig deeper into the topic, I included a booklet that contains all the research, discussions of visibility, and the fact that the design within the visualizations has all been ideated by the plus size people I worked with. Looking back at the visualizations, the person should be able to understand the context behind every design decision, and what role visibility plays in making a market legitimate. The way this project was conducted should also give people an idea of the creativity that can come from involving the target group in the design process, and by adding the IFF mapping method in the booklet, I have given upcoming designers a tool that can be used for such means, which may hopefully lead to fulfilling the goal of inspiring others to make projects addressing diversity issues in fashion for the future.

7. Reflection

This project has been a complicated journey for me. Not because of limited information available or difficulties in finding collaborators, but because of the complexity of the topic. I noticed it when using the mapping methods such as the four spheres and metadesign nest. The data I have collected can be connected in multiple ways to make its own topic to explore for another project. For example, with my research, a project could be made about online shopping and its overreliance by people, and how buying clothes without knowing if they fit, and unnecessary shipping back and forth, makes it both an environmental and economic burden. A project could be made about size guides and their ineffectiveness when looking for clothes, or a project about alternative ways to get plus size clothing that does not rely on the fast fashion market.

I thought about all of these potential directions that my project could have gone in, especially when the topic has felt too broad to me. In the end I am glad that I stuck with visibility as my main focus, as I believe it was the most effective way to accomplish my goal, which was to be able to communicate the impact of a lack of legitimacy plus size fashion has as a market and why it is an issue. I believe that visibility could be considered the biggest factor to the multiple issues found within plus size fashion, the reason being the lack of proper communication with its intended customer base in stores due to stigmatization around fatness, as well as the standardization of clothes making, as part of the symbolic visibility. I felt that for a project like this, where the target group has not had their wants and needs heard, it was important for me to base my project around making the conversation around plus size fashion visible.

I struggled with deciding whether or not to stay within the current fashion market for my project. It is tempting, when you are working with speculative design, to imagine a system outside the current market. While I did not specify what kind of system we were under when working on the IFF mapping with my co-designers, I noticed what they all had in mind was still a store. When I asked one of them about it, we ended up having a discussion that I found to be an interesting thought process. When we make a space that is separate from the general market, are we being inclusive or are we excluding a group? After all, visibility is not just about being able to see yourself in models, advertising and clothes, it is about feeling like you are acknowledged and included in society. I have come to view the co-designed store XAVIO as a showcase of how the current surface level attempts at size inclusiveness falls flat, on an industrial level, thanks to the standardization we have in place.

I have learnt from this project that when you are collecting data from a certain group through a questionnaire, it is beneficial to do so through a collaborator within the field you base your topic on. When I had published the first questionnaire and received little answers, I got worried that I would not be able to gather enough data. It was especially harrowing to see the answers I did get were short and not very descriptive. Looking back, I believe the questions I asked might have benefitted more if they were part of a discussion, rather than something you answer on your own. I could see it more clearly after I had made my second questionnaire with the store owner in Norrköping, where I not only got more answers, but the answers I got were more detailed. It was no doubt thanks to my collaborator, who is knowledgeable about the topic, and could therefore help the participants with the questionnaire. For future design projects where I have to collect data through questionnaires, I will make sure to establish a collaboration with a stakeholder as the first step.

The co-design in my project had been the most challenging part. I found the choice I made to turn the co-design into one-on-one sessions to be a good choice, as the participants were willing to open up more to me, and by having more space for them to talk. Bigger groups could lead to more discussions and different ideas at the same time, although with less time to develop each of them. By working with one participant at a time, we could develop each idea. It also gave me time to develop an understanding of the design decisions made by my participants. For the future I will have to consider whether I am aiming for quantity or quality when conducting participatory design projects.

The idea of using a set of body types rather than one body we have set as an ideal, is something I see a lot of potential in, as a new guide system for clothing. The idea came from a conversation with my collaborator in Norrköping, when she introduced me to the terms “A-shape” and “V-shape”, which was later brought up again and developed further during the co-design process. This means that the XAVIO guide has had the most development from both a market perspective and target group perspective. If there is anything I would like to bring with me from this project, it is definitely the XAVIO guide. I find its concept compelling in what it can suggest by combining it with the current size chart. Small, medium and large would feel more like a description of the scale of the body the clothes are fit for, rather than the shape that would be provided by the XAVIO guide.

I have a potential future collaborator if I were to take my project further, as I had visited an art gallery when I went to Norrköping. When I told her about my project, she surprised me with an offer to host an exhibition. This was both nerve wracking and exciting, as I had not created XAVIO yet and did not know what this exhibition would entail. Now that the visualizations are done, I have more confidence to take the offer. I felt encouraged by this interaction, as it signaled to me that people are not just capable of, but fully willing to have the discussion of plus size clothing when you open up a space for it. Perhaps this exhibition could be the next step towards making XAVIO public on a larger scale, and hopefully be an intriguing concept for people within the fashion industry.

8. Summary

In my project XXLargely seen, I sought out to explore and criticize the invisibility of plus size fashion in the general fashion market, with the goal of bringing the topic into public discussion. Using speculative design as a method, the project was split into two stages, the “what is?”, where I focused on data collecting through field studies and questionnaires, and the “what if?”, where I conducted co-design sessions with other plus size people with the goal of creating an ideal fashion future.

From my field studies, I found that most mannequins and models in advertisements were thin, and that the stores were unclear with the size ranges for their products. However, the size ranges were clearly displayed on their online stores, which meant that plus size people were relegated to online spaces to find clothing instead of getting to be a part of the physical store space. From my questionnaire, I found out that plus size people were aware of this, and were not pleased with it. They were unhappy with the difficulties they faced in finding quality clothing that fit them for a reasonable price, and it was affecting their self esteem.

When conducting my co-design sessions, the needs and wants of the participants were: a space with a lot of room to walk in, clearer communication of size ranges on the signs, diversity of body types in clothing, mannequins and models in advertising, as well as a secondhand area to give people a way to save money. To conclude the project, I compiled all these ideas into one store design named XAVIO, where I made visualizations to present to the public. With XAVIO, I wanted to bring awareness of the lack of visibility of plus size fashion in the fashion market by showing people what a plus size inclusive store could look like in the future. By bringing body type diversity into the space, I addressed how our current standardization in fashion favors one body type, while my design favors five different body types. The involvement of my collaborators were important for me to emphasize. There is a lot of creativity and new ways of thinking that comes out of a group that is usually not seen. My hope with this project is that for upcoming designers and people within the fashion industry, I have made this visible.

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